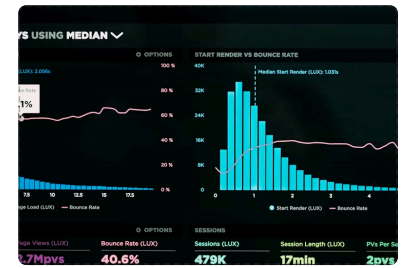


"WE CAN'T DO AI UNTIL THE DATA'S SORTED"

It's reasonable advice — the master data's a mess, the ERP doesn't talk to the planning tool, three systems hold a version of the customer that none of them agree on. But the foundations project has a start date, a budget and a steering committee. What it doesn't have, and never has, is a finish date.



66%

EFFICIENCY GAIN

of finance teams using AI report greater efficiency and productivity

63%

SLOWER THAN EXPECTED

said implementation went slower than expected in 2025

Gartner, March 2026 survey of 204 finance leaders

WHERE THE BLOCKER ACTUALLY MOVES TO You can export a file today, point a model at it with the right instructions and proper checks, and it will do work that used to take a week — no integration project required. But a few weeks in, the constraint stops being the data and becomes the person reading the output. Who on the team can look at a plausible, beautifully formatted answer and spot the assumption that's quietly wrong? Who's curious enough to keep taking the process apart rather than accepting the first draft? That's the real audit — and it can't happen while everyone is still waiting for the systems project to land.

WHAT THIS MEANS IN PRACTICE

01 PICK ONE PROCESS THIS MONTH

Choose something that doesn't need a system change to try — board commentary, a reconciliation, a first-draft forecast. Export, upload, run it properly, then compare the result to what a person produced. One process, four weeks, a real answer either way.

02 WRITE THE CHECKS BEFORE THE PROMPT

Traceable formulas and a documented source for every assumption, before you write a word to the model. A marketing team can live with an odd hallucination in a first draft; someone will ask you where a number came from eleven months after you produced it, and the answer needs to exist.

03 KEEP THE SYSTEMS ROADMAP RUNNING

Same pace, same budget, no pause. This is what you do while the foundations are being laid, not instead of doing it — the teams that get this wrong pick one and quietly drop the other.

04 WATCH WHO TAKES TO IT

The person who rebuilds the output twice because the first version wasn't good enough has just told you something a competency framework never would. They're your next AI-in-Finance champion — and possibly the case for keeping someone else exactly where they are.

The data will never be finished — that's just what data looks like in a growing business, with another acquisition, another product line, another system somebody bought without asking. The better question is whether you're willing to work in the house while it's being fixed, and whether the people in there with you are the ones you'd want alongside you when it's done.

**THE SYSTEMS PROJECT WILL TAKE EIGHTEEN MONTHS.
ONE EXPORTED FILE CAN START ON TUESDAY.**